

Never gone, but now making his presence felt

With his confidence being sky-high and form at its peak, call him old or call him a find.

Shashank Singh, at 32, does not mind!

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At 32, Shashank Singh has spent nearly 10 years in domestic cricket. He got his first IPL contract over six years ago. Yet, it is only now that he's being hailed as the big discovery of IPL 2024. Welcome to Shashank's world!

Shashank made his debut in senior domestic limited-overs cricket during the 2014-15 season. He earned his first Ranji Trophy cap five years later. In this IPL, he has been one of the standout performers, consistently delivering impressive performances as a middle-order batter. "It feels good when someone refers to me as a find. Ultimately, that's because I have been able to back myself, showcase my potential, and deliver frequently this IPL season," a relaxed Shashank tells *Sportstar*. "People like you follow domestic cricket so closely that you know that I have been around the circuit for a decade now. I am not sure how I have fared, but I have survived. I have always been confident about my abilities, and I am glad I have been able to execute them better."

Shashank doesn't shy away from hitting good balls out of the park, but

one cannot ignore his tendency to downplay himself. The fact that it took him a lot of time to cement a place in a side — domestic or IPL — seems to have made him more practical in his approach.

Growing up in Bhilai and representing Madhya Pradesh in Under-15 and Under-17 cricket, Shashank, the son of a police officer and telecommunications officer, moved to Mumbai with his family to pursue his cricketing dreams.

Although he made it to Mumbai Under-19, his senior debut was delayed. He finally made the cut as an all-rounder in the 2014-15 season, but despite his effective medium-pace bowling, he struggled to secure a regular spot in the team. In 2018-19, he tried his luck in Pondicherry but eventually returned to Chhattisgarh, which was a recognised member of the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) by now. During his debut season with Chhattisgarh, Shashank played a crucial role in securing its first-ever victory over Mumbai in all formats at the senior level.

While competing in Mumbai's maidans, Shashank had caught the eye of IPL scouts, earning stints with

Delhi Daredevils (now Capitals) and Rajasthan Royals between 2017 and 2021. His IPL debut was with Sunrisers Hyderabad in 2022, but he was released and went unsold in the 2023 auction. Fast forward to 2024, and Shashank's fortunes have turned. His heroics for Punjab Kings, including a stunning unbeaten 68 off 28 balls, helped his team chase down the highest-ever IPL target of 262 with eight balls to spare. Shashank, unaffected by his past setbacks, embraces his success this time. "This is a byproduct of all the struggles I have had at various levels. I have learned from every failure and little success I have had over all these years," he says.

He chuckles at being called "old", just as he does when dubbed "the find of the season". Thanks to his morning yoga routine and countless hours on the cricket grounds across India, Shashank seems to be in his prime. His knack for breaking down challenging targets, like turning 127 off 54 balls into "six sixes and six fours," shows his confidence. Age doesn't bother him; he's focused on emulating his Mumbai teammates to reach his dream of playing for India.

"I have been playing with Pravin